HARBOURLIGHT MEDIA

Clearance Guide: Alcohol and Social Success

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1. What this guide covers

This guide covers alcohol copy that links drinking with popularity, confidence, social or sexual success, or daring. It is used by the Clearance Executive who reviews the copy, from the first read until the issue is settled, and by Agency Liaisons advising agencies before they submit.

It arises in alcohol copy only.

This guide is about what the drink is shown to do. A performer who is, or looks, under 25 is an appeal to under-18s, and the Appeal to Under-18s guide covers it.

Whether a campaign's spots may be transmitted is a separate question, settled by the category's own code. This guide is about the copy.

2. How it usually shows up

- the drinker becoming the life of the party or the centre of attention after a drink
- a round of drinks turning someone into the most popular person in the room
- a group that only starts having fun once the drinks arrive
- confidence to take the stage, or a daring stunt, straight after drinking
- the drink shown as the key to a great night out

3. What the executive checks

For a possible link between drinking and social success, the Clearance Executive checks, in this order:

1. Watch the copy scene by scene and note where the drink appears against any change in a character's mood or standing.
2. Decide whether the drink causes the success in the story or is incidental to a scene of friends meeting.
3. Check that no line or super credits the drink with confidence, popularity, attraction or courage.
4. Check the copy does not show drinking to excess, or drinking linked with daring, driving or danger.
5. Ask for the storyboard when the order of the scenes decides the question.

4. Evidence to ask for

- the storyboard and the edit showing the order of the scenes
- the script, with every line and super

5. When the copy can be cleared

The copy can be cleared once the drink is incidental to any social scene and nothing suggests it brings confidence, popularity or success. The usual amendment is to cut the moment a character is cheered or transformed after drinking, or the line that links the two.

6. What the agency should do

Before submitting, and when answering a query, the agency should:

- Show friends enjoying each other's company, with the drink incidental.
- Avoid any change in a character that follows the drink.
- Keep lines and supers from crediting the drink with confidence or popularity.
- Send the storyboard with the copy.

7. When to ask for a legal review

Ask for a legal review when the agency argues that the scene shows friends meeting rather than the drink causing the fun.

The Legal Adviser records the review on the campaign, and its view carries more weight than any other note.

8. Recording the outcome

The outcome is recorded in an update on the campaign: the copy amended, the evidence accepted, or the copy cleared as submitted.

The assessment then recommends one of the decisions open for the campaign, and a Clearance Controller decides, as the Advertising Clearance Policy describes. Copy that cannot be cleared is rejected, whatever its spots' results.